

research, you need something like the MantaDB suite of utilities—a suite of eight tools which add extra capabilities to your browser. One of the most powerful tools is the Web Page Indexer, which scans the Web pages you've viewed and remembers which words came from which page. Think of it as a search engine for all the pages you've viewed. If you've ever been in a situation where you could not return to a page you know you have once seen, then MantaDB is for you. Other utilities are self explanatory: the LinkChecker, Personal Sidebar, Page DeFramer, Web Page AutoRefresh, Font Size and Sensible Colors.

Powermarks, an alternative bookmarking utility to your browsers, transforms your bookmarks into your own personalised Web directory. Clicking category tabs also instantly sorts your bookmarks in ascending or descending order. Powermarks adds keywords to your bookmarks when you import them and creates a 'dictionary' of these words. Click on any keyword in the dictionary window, and voila! You have a list of all related links in your collection.

A few tweaks to your browser, like increasing the cache size, cutting down on images and multimedia would go a long way in improving your speed. To make a Web page available offline, add it to your Favorites then click Make Available Offline. IE stores the Web page, complete with graphics, into a temporary folder. The history folder is a good way to search for information stored in your browser's cache. You can sort the information in many ways. It surely beats saving the document at any place and having to search through them again.

Power searching

Successful searching involves two key steps. First, you must have a clear understanding of how to prepare your search. To use search engines effectively, it is essential to apply techniques that narrow down results and push the most relevant pages to the top of the results list. Second, you need to know how to use the various search tools available on the Internet. Search engines (Google, AltaVista) are very different from subject directories (Yahoo!, InfoSpace). Search engines themselves can vary greatly in size, accuracy, features, and flexibility.

650 million
Usenet messages dating back to the mid-1990s have been electronically resurrected by Google

What is an Internet Directory?

An Internet directory is an index or directory of Web sites classified according to subject categories. Directories are also useful for finding information on a topic when you don't have a precise idea of what you need. Many large directories include a keyword search option, which usually eliminates the need to work through numerous levels of topics and subtopics. Because directories cover only a small fraction of the pages available on the Web, they are most effective for finding general information on popular or scholarly subjects. If you are looking for something specific, use a search engine. Yahoo! is an example of a wide-ranging Web directory which covers many popular subject areas. Encyclopaedia Britannica, on the other hand, is a more exclusive directory covering subject categories that are more academically oriented.

Web sites within an Internet directory are often arranged in a hierarchical manner beginning with more general subject categories and advancing to more specific ones. Many directories contain a search engine component to help the user navigate through the various levels of subject categories.

No report looks as good without statistics, and the Internet is a handy resource to extract statistical data from market research sites. To corroborate your points with statistics, check out Statistics.com and Forrester.com. Forrester Research provides demographic analysis of Web users and the penetration of the PC market, including age and income bracket analysis.

Because search engines vary in ability to interpret complex searches, it's a good idea to start your search on a meta-search engine. Meta-search engines act as a middle agent, passing on the query to the major search engines and then returning the results. Dogpile, AskJeeves, and MetaCrawler fall in this category.

Along similar lines is a desktop search utility called Copernic 2000, which simultaneously accesses 65 search engines on the Web. Copernic filters out and eliminates repeat documents found on more than one engine. It also offers detailed search histories so that found documents can be viewed, downloaded or refined at any time. Copernic 2000 can also automatically eliminate outdated documents and download documents selected for consultation at any time.

It's not just HTTP

Contrary to many people's understanding, the Internet consists of more than just Web pages and e-mail. The resources/tools that comprise the Internet are myriad—message boards, online databases, online catalogs, Usenet newsgroups, FTP servers, and online chats/discussion groups to name a few. Learning about them and how they are used will help you determine how they are most applicable to your research.

Usenet

Usenet is a set of people who exchange articles tagged with one or more universally recognised labels, called 'newsgroups'. Usenet is a worldwide discussion system consisting of a set of newsgroups with names that are classified hierarchically by subject—for example, alt.rec.phish and alt.music.tool for the subject music. 'Articles' or 'messages' are 'posted' to these newsgroups by people on computers with the appropriate software.

Usenet is available on a wide variety of computer systems and networks and its strengths lie in its decentralised nature and lack of rules. However, its weaknesses are also its decentralised nature and lack of rules.

Mailing lists

As newsgroups are public discussions in which you subscribe and participate, mailing lists are lists of e-mail addresses of people interested in a similar topic. Mailing lists can be public or private, ranging from as few as two participants to as many as thousands. A mailing list may be very active or it may be extremely slow. You should always subscribe to one mailing list at a time. If, however, you subscribe to multiple active mailing lists simultaneously, you will quickly find yourself overwhelmed with a huge volume of e-mail messages you cannot possibly read. Start off with one mailing list and then expand slowly.